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The Masai

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When an acquaintance wants to enter the hut, he calls -- corresponding to our knock -- "e[unknown] n op[unknown] en e[unknown] ng adjl" = female owner of the hut, whereupon from inside, like "Come in!" comes the answer, "j[unknown] a na ij[unknown] ok" = "we are here." Thanks for a favor shown or a gift is hardly ever customary, only very rarely does one hear the word [unknown]asch[unknown] e = thanks. A request is refused in that one "warns off" with the hand, the palm of which is turned toward the one making the request.

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The farewell runs "aija amalo" if one person is going away, "aija amerda 109 kipo" if several take their leave, and means "I am going" or "we are going." It is used similarly by all people and only by uncircumcised children is not accompanied by the handshake. A friend taking his leave is requested to remain longer with "milo" = "do not go." In conversation with their kind the Masai are very talkative. The warriors among themselves relate old and new war adventures, which are presented with lively gestures and in exaggerated embellishment. Usually a fellow tribesman or lineage member plays the leading role in it; the enemy is always cowardly or lets himself be outwitted. Together with the young girls, the conversation soon becomes unrestrained and launches into racy witticisms and bold jokes. In the kraal of the married, men and women sit in separate groups. The former speak quietly and often in subdued voices about memories of their youth, stock raising, etc.; the latter, on the other hand, laughing and with extraordinary glibness of tongue, converse about gossipy tales in which some slur is cast on Mr. or Mrs. So-and-So. But let it be said to the credit of the Masai that their gossip is childish and harmless. One does not find malicious scandalmongers of either sex among the Masai and probably not among the other so-called primitive

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peoples. They rather seem to be an attendant phenomenon of a higher level of culture. In accordance with the lively, impulsive nature and especially also the abnormal irascibility of the younger men, one very often hears coarse and bantering invectives. Their coarseness probably sufficiently explains the peculiar ethics of the Masai. Crude invectives may not be used by women toward men.

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